

Public speaking basics

COMPLETE LEARNING GUIDE

What You'll Learn

Public speaking shows up in placements far more often than students expect: a group discussion is public speaking to a small panel, an interview answer to 'walk me through your project' is a short prepared talk, and many companies include a presentation round or require presenting a project to a team after joining. The core fear most students report — freezing up, forgetting what to say, visible nervousness — is addressed less by 'just be confident' advice and more by concrete techniques: structuring a talk so you always know what comes next, breathing techniques that physically reduce anxiety symptoms, and practicing in a way that builds real fluency rather than memorized-and-fragile scripts. This sub-module gives a repeatable structure for any short talk, techniques for managing nervousness in the moment, and a plan for practicing that produces steady improvement rather than one-off cramming.

1. Why Nervousness Happens and How to Manage It Physically

Public speaking anxiety is a physical stress response (increased heart rate, shallow breathing, tension) as much as a mental one, which is why purely mental reassurance ('you'll be fine') often doesn't help in the moment. Box breathing — inhale for 4 counts, hold for 4, exhale for 4, hold for 4, repeated 3-4 times — directly slows heart rate and is discreet enough to do while waiting outside an interview room or just before your turn in a GD. Arriving early enough to sit quietly for a few minutes rather than rushing in also reduces the baseline stress level before you even start speaking. Physical grounding techniques matter because they address the actual physiological cause of 'my mind went blank,' which is usually oxygen and adrenaline, not lack of preparation.

- Box breathing (4-4-4-4) for 3-4 cycles before a high-stakes speaking moment measurably lowers heart rate within about a minute.
- Standing or sitting with an open, upright posture for two minutes before speaking has been shown to reduce self-reported anxiety compared to a slumped posture.

2. A Repeatable Structure for Any Short Talk

Rather than memorizing a talk word-for-word (fragile — one forgotten line derails everything), learn a structure and fill it in each time: an opening hook that states what you'll cover or opens with a relevant fact/question, a body with 2-3 clearly signposted points ('First... Second... Finally...'), and a closing that summarizes and, where relevant, states a takeaway or call to action. This structure works whether you're explaining a project in an interview, giving a 2-minute self-introduction, or presenting to a class, because it gives you fixed waypoints — even if you go blank mid-point, you know the shape of what comes next and can recover.

- Opening hook example (project explanation): 'I built a tool that cut our team's manual data-entry time from 3 hours a week to about 20 minutes.'
- Signposted body example: 'There were three parts to this — first the data pipeline, second the validation logic, and third the dashboard the team actually uses.'
- Closing example: 'So overall, the project taught me how to take a manual process and systematically automate it — which is the same instinct I'd bring to this role.'

3. Vocal Delivery: Pace, Pause, and Projection

Delivery mechanics matter as much as content: speaking too quickly (a common nervous habit) makes a talk harder to follow and signals anxiety; speaking in a monotone makes even good content forgettable. A deliberate pause after a key sentence — rather than rushing into the next thought — gives the point weight and gives the speaker a moment to think ahead. Projection (speaking loud enough to be clearly heard without straining) should be calibrated to the room; in a one-on-one interview this is rarely an issue, but in a group presentation or larger room, many speakers under-project because they're nervous, and it makes them harder to take seriously.

4. Body Language While Speaking to a Group

In a one-on-one interview, eye contact stays mostly with one person; when addressing a small group (a GD panel, a presentation audience), effective speakers scan across the group rather than fixating on one listener, giving everyone a sense of being addressed. Standing (or sitting, if seated) with an open stance — feet planted, weight even, hands available for natural gesture rather than jammed in pockets or gripping a paper — reads as composed. Purposeful movement (a step to transition between points) can add energy; nervous pacing or repetitive fidgeting (clicking a pen, tapping a foot) distracts from the content.

5. Using Notes Without Reading From Them

Notes should function as a safety net, not a script — a card with 3-5 keyword prompts (not full sentences) for each point is enough to keep a talk on track without reducing the speaker to reading aloud, which kills engagement and eye contact. If you find yourself needing full sentences on a card, it usually means the structure isn't internalized well enough yet, and more practice with the structure (not more detailed notes) is the right fix. Glancing at a card briefly between points, rather than reading continuously, is a normal and acceptable behavior even in professional settings.

- Good note card for a project explanation: 'Problem !' Data pipeline !' Validation !' Dashboard !' Impact (3hrs!'20min)' — five keyword prompts, not sentences.

6. Handling Q&A and Unexpected Questions

The Q&A portion of any talk, or a follow-up question in an interview, is where prepared speeches often break down because the speaker hasn't rehearsed responding to the unexpected. The key technique is to pause briefly (1-2 seconds is fine and looks thoughtful, not unprepared), restate the question briefly if it's complex ('So you're asking whether this approach would scale to a larger dataset — '), and answer directly before adding supporting detail, rather than launching into a long wind-up. If a question is genuinely unclear, asking for

clarification ('Could you clarify what you mean by scale — team size or data volume?') is far better than guessing and answering the wrong question confidently.

- If you don't know an answer: 'I haven't worked with that specific tool, but based on similar tools I've used, here's how I'd approach it...' is far stronger than bluffing or going silent.

7. Practicing With Feedback Loops

Improvement in public speaking comes from practicing in a way that surfaces what you can't see yourself doing — reading a speech silently in your head does almost nothing for actual delivery. Recording yourself on video and watching it back (ideally muted first, to judge body language separately from content) exposes filler words, pacing issues, and posture habits invisible in the moment. Practicing in front of even one other person and asking for specific feedback ('Was my pacing okay? Did I look at you enough?') is more useful than vague feedback ('that was good') — ask pointed questions to get pointed answers. Mock GD and mock interview sessions, repeated over weeks rather than crammed the night before, are what actually build fluency.

Common Pitfalls

- Memorizing a talk word-for-word, which collapses entirely if one line is forgotten mid-delivery.
- Speaking noticeably faster when nervous, making the talk harder to follow and signaling anxiety to listeners.
- Reading directly and continuously from notes instead of using them as brief keyword prompts.
- Avoiding pauses out of fear that silence looks unprepared, when a deliberate pause actually signals composure.
- Answering a Q&A question with a long wind-up before ever getting to the actual answer.
- Practicing only by reading silently rather than recording and reviewing actual spoken delivery.
- Fixating eye contact on only one person in a group setting instead of scanning across listeners.

Key Takeaways

- Nervousness is physical as well as mental — box breathing and posture changes address it directly before you even start speaking.
- Learn a repeatable structure (hook, 2-3 signposted points, close) instead of memorizing exact wording.
- Notes should be keyword prompts, not scripts — reading verbatim kills engagement and eye contact.
- In Q&A, pause, restate if needed, and answer directly before adding detail.
- Recording yourself and reviewing it (muted, for body language) is the fastest way to improve delivery.

- Consistent practice over weeks builds real fluency; cramming the night before builds fragile memorization.

Learn More

Toastmasters International — Tips for Public Speaking

<https://www.toastmasters.org/resources/public-speaking-tips>

Harvard Business Review — How to Overcome Your Fear of Public Speaking

<https://hbr.org/2018/07/how-to-overcome-your-fear-of-public-speaking>

MindTools — Effective Speaking

<https://www.mindtools.com/CmTTr9r/effective-speaking>